USDA

One-page brief

Priority: 4 of 33 (score 3.9). **FY2026 outlays:** $220B (USAspending). **As of:** 2026-10-27 (first written 2026-10-25). Public data only.

Bottom line

USDA brings two strong targets: SNAP retailer trafficking and child meal sponsor fraud, the pattern behind Minnesota's $250M Feeding Our Future case. Both are DOJ whistleblower priorities (SNAP and day care). Public data name the retailers and the grantees, but not the transactions, so we score entities, not purchases.

Exposure

- SNAP: $10.2B improper (10.9%). Child and Adult Care Food Program: 10.5%. Emergency Conservation Program: 55.5%. Noninsured Crop Disaster Assistance: 10.6%. (GAO, FY2025)
- Feeding Our Future: $250M scheme, 78 people charged.

Public data we can use

- **SNAP authorized retailer data** (store type, location, authorization dates) and published retailer disqualification actions.
- **USAspending** grants and payments, including farm program and nutrition grants to states and sponsors.
- **State CACFP sponsor and site lists**, where states publish them.
- **USDA OIG reports** and DOJ releases.

Detection plays

1. **Retailer outliers:** small stores in dense clusters, new authorizations near already disqualified stores, and owners linked to past violators.
2. **Meal sponsor anomalies:** sites claiming more meals than local child population supports, sudden growth, and shared sponsors across many sites.
3. **Farm disaster payments:** recipients far above local peers, or payments tied to entities with shared officers.

First prototype

A SNAP retailer risk map for two states, scoring each store against nearby peers and known disqualified stores, plus a sponsor screen for one state that publishes CACFP site lists.

Limits

SNAP redemption data by store are not public, so trafficking is inferred from location and ownership, not sales. CACFP data vary by state.

Who to take it to

The Food and Nutrition Service (Retailer Operations), USDA OIG, and state SNAP and child nutrition agencies.

Related briefs

treasury.pdf and ssa.pdf (other means-tested benefits), doe.pdf (SBIR screen).

Sources

- GAO-26-108694: FY2025 improper payments
- NBC: Minnesota child care findings and Feeding Our Future
- DOJ whistleblower program scope